

important difference between the Net as it was in the '90s and as it is now is how US-dominated it was earlier: the Internet pretty much was America back then.

Commercial dial-up access to the Internet began way back in 1990, with The World (world.std.com) coming into the nascent market. The same year, Sir Tim Berners-Lee wrote the first browser for the WWW. The browser itself was called WorldWideWeb, and the first version was finished on Christmas day. URLs, HTML, and HTTP were all his creations, and he used these in his model of the WWW—an information-sharing model built on top of the Internet.

It comes as a surprise to most of us that the WWW was not invented by an American, and not in America: the WWW project was at CERN (the European Laboratory for Particle Physics; "CERN" is how it comes out in French.)

By 1991, the WWW was put in place by CERN. Two years later, Mosaic—the first graphics-based Web browser—was received rather enthusiastically by the growing population of Netizens, as you might imagine. Netscape Communications Corp. was formed in 1994, by Marc Andreessen and Jim Clark. Their first browser was out the same year, as Netscape Navigator 1.0, and "Web browsing" became a standard term. Andreessen was on the cover of Time Magazine in 1996, under an article called "The Golden Geeks." Right on the cover of Time Magazine, Andreessen sported a near-comical, sneering grin. Netscape ruled: the browser wars had begun, and Netscape was much better than IE at the time. We remember installing Netscape on our Windows 95 machines, even though IE was there by default.

Well, Microsoft wasn't stupid,

and kept improving IE; by 1998, the war was over, Microsoft won, and Netscape released the source code for Navigator to the public domain.

What use is a browser without a search engine? Back in 1997, we remember, most folks' default start page was Yahoo!. It had a human-edited directory—and then came the major searchbots. The notables at the time were HotBot and AltaVista. Then in 1998, Google happened. It was initially a competitor to AltaVista and a couple of other search engines. You know the rest.

The killer app of the Web back then was, obviously, Web-based e-mail ("Access your e-mail anytime, anyplace!"). Hotmail, the first Web mail service, was launched July 4, 1996. It was a killer idea, and once it was out, a million companies followed. Yahoo!, Hotmail, and Google were the WWW staples towards the end of the '90s.

1999 saw the emergence of Napster, and the P2P revolution, for lack of a less clichéd word. Napster was a file-sharing service for music, and people "shared" music like it was the '60s, what with free love and all. Everyone was happy, except the music companies. Come to think of it, "revolution" is a good fit there: Time Magazine's October 2000 cover featured Shawn Fanning, Napster's sole creator, in an article called "How Shawn Fanning, 19, upended music... and a lot more."

And what's P2P without broadband? It was in 1998 that broadband began to be aggressively advertised: "Get 50 times the speed of your dial-up modem." By 1999, 1 Mbps and 2 Mbps DSL connections were routine. (Yes, India is a developing country.) DSL had a competitor in the form cable TV operators who provided broadband connections at the same price.

We've sidelined so many things talking about the Net experience, and indeed, the rest wasn't much in the news. OK, some of it was: in 1996, IBM's Deep Blue defeated world chess champion Gary Kasparov. Sony's robotic dog, the Aibo, came out in 1999. DVD became popular in '98, and did for movies what the CD had done for music: towards the end of the decade, a computer was considered incomplete without a DVD drive.

The Palm Pilot improved PDA capabilities in 1996, and again towards the end of the decade, everyone wanted "a Palm."

Cell phones in India were for the rich folk circa 1996, but soon trickled down. On the other side of the planet, there were 90 million cell phone connections in 2000.

Yes, it all happened in the '90s, for sure. The Nintendo 64. The Sony PlayStation. Java. Bluetooth. The finalisation of the initial standard for wireless LANs, IEEE 802.11. And last but definitely not least, Linux!

There's a lot we've glossed over here, but anyway, by 2000, the world was networked—and that's what matters. ■

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The WWW

What we absolutely must declare as the defining technology event of the 1990s is the development and expansion of the World Wide Web. We're sure you'll agree.

Some background about Berners-Lee: in 1980, he was an independent contractor at CERN, and felt the need to build a system to aid in sharing information amongst the researchers there. Sir Tim thought about hypertext for this purpose, and along with another researcher, built a prototype system called Enquire. As you can guess, it was something like a wiki. It wasn't published, but it served the purpose, and remained a private thing. Much later, in 1989, Berners-Lee thought about using the same ideas as in Enquire to create a global network. It was conceptually simple, and as he put it, "I just had to take the hypertext idea and connect it to the TCP and DNS ideas and—ta-da!—the World Wide Web." CERN liked the idea. Later on, we all did.

